

INDIRA GANDHI NATIONAL OPEN UNIVERSITY

B.A. TOURISM STUDIES (BTS)

**Role of Salugara Monastery in Promoting Buddhist
Cultural Tourism in Siliguri Region**

Programme Code: BTS

Course Code: PTS-1

Enrolment No.: _____

Study Centre Code: _____

Regional Centre: _____

Name of Candidate: _____

Project Report submitted in partial fulfillment of the requirements for the award of Bachelor Degree in
Tourism Studies.

Year: 2026

DECLARATION

I hereby declare that this project report is my original work and has not been submitted, either in full or in part, to any other institution or university for any academic award. All sources used in this report have been acknowledged appropriately.

Signature of Candidate: _____ Name: _____ Date:

CERTIFICATE BY SUPERVISOR

Certified that the Project Report entitled _____ submitted by _____ is his/her own work and has been completed under my supervision. It is recommended that this project be placed before the examiner for evaluation.

Signature of Supervisor: _____ Name: _____ Study Centre: _____
Regional Centre: _____ Date: _____

ACKNOWLEDGEMENT

I sincerely thank my project supervisor for valuable guidance, feedback, and motivation throughout this study. I am grateful to the monastic representatives, local residents, service providers, and visitors who shared their time and views during field interactions. Their cooperation made this work meaningful and grounded in practical realities.

I also acknowledge the academic support provided through IGNOU study materials and project guidelines. Any errors in interpretation remain my own responsibility.

TABLE OF CONTENTS (Indicative)

1. ABSTRACT
2. CHAPTER 1: INTRODUCTION
3. CHAPTER 2: REVIEW OF LITERATURE AND CONCEPTUAL FRAMEWORK
4. CHAPTER 3: RESEARCH METHODOLOGY
5. CHAPTER 4: STUDY AREA PROFILE
6. CHAPTER 5: DATA ANALYSIS AND FINDINGS
7. CHAPTER 6: RECOMMENDATIONS AND ACTION FRAMEWORK
8. CHAPTER 7: CONCLUSION
9. BIBLIOGRAPHY
10. ANNEXURES

ABSTRACT

This project examines how Salugara Monastery contributes to Buddhist cultural tourism in and around Siliguri, with selective comparison to nearby monasteries such as Sed-Gyued, Ewam India, and Dali. The study is framed within the IGNOU BTS theme of Indian culture, environment, and tourism, and uses a mixed-method field approach combining visitor surveys, interviews with monks and local stakeholders, and structured observation of site facilities and tourist flow patterns.

The analysis finds that Salugara Monastery functions simultaneously as a sacred space, a heritage landmark, and a soft gateway to wider Himalayan Buddhist circuits. Its iconic stupa, prayer ambience, accessible location on the Siliguri corridor, and openness to non-Buddhist visitors make it a culturally meaningful and tourism-relevant site. Visitor motivations combine religious devotion, curiosity about Buddhist philosophy, search for mental peace, and incidental stopover behaviour by travelers transiting through Siliguri to Darjeeling, Kalimpong, Sikkim, and the Northeast.

The project also documents practical constraints: uneven interpretation facilities, limited digital outreach, inadequate multilingual signage, limited formal guide systems, and weak integrated destination packaging. Community interviews indicate that monastery tourism contributes to local micro-economies through food, transport, retail, and short-stay accommodation; however, these benefits are diffuse and not yet structured through coordinated destination planning. Environmental and cultural concerns include crowd pressure on peak days, litter spillovers in surrounding lanes, and risks of ritual commodification.

The report recommends a responsible Buddhist cultural tourism model for Salugara: improved interpretation, visitor code of conduct, multilingual communication, better wayfinding, annual event calendars, digital visibility strategy, women-led local enterprise support, and cluster linkage with nearby monasteries. The study argues that Salugara can evolve from a largely pass-through stop to a high-quality cultural node if tourism development remains monastery-led, community-inclusive, and values-based. The findings are relevant for local planners, destination marketers, and tourism students working on heritage-linked sustainable tourism models in medium-sized Indian gateway cities.

CHAPTER 1: INTRODUCTION

Tourism in India increasingly reflects a shift from conventional sightseeing toward experience-based travel. Within this shift, Buddhist cultural tourism occupies a special place because it combines pilgrimage, heritage interpretation, meditation-oriented travel, and transnational spiritual interest. Siliguri, often described as the gateway to the Eastern Himalayas, is strategically located at the intersection of major roads and rail networks connecting West Bengal, Sikkim, Bhutan border zones, Darjeeling hills, and the Northeast region. This mobility geography makes Siliguri an ideal transit as well as short-stay tourism node.

In this urban and peri-urban setting, Salugara Monastery represents a culturally significant Buddhist site. The monastery's stupa and prayer environment attract not only practicing Buddhists but also general visitors looking for calm environments and meaningful cultural engagement. However, despite visible tourist interest, formal documentation on how this monastery supports cultural tourism, local livelihoods, and destination identity remains limited. Most narratives are anecdotal, and very little student-level field-based work integrates visitor behaviour, resident perceptions, and management

viewpoints in one study.

The present project responds to this gap. It investigates the role played by Salugara Monastery in promoting Buddhist cultural tourism in the Siliguri region and situates the findings in a wider cluster context with selected nearby monasteries. The study assumes that cultural tourism development is strongest where authenticity, accessibility, interpretation, and local participation are simultaneously present. It further assumes that unmanaged growth can produce cultural dilution and environmental pressure; therefore, quality of growth matters more than volume alone.

Statement of the Problem: Salugara Monastery attracts visitors and is symbolically important for Buddhist identity in the region, yet there is no consolidated local framework that documents its tourism role, evaluates visitor experience, and links site-level practices with destination-level planning for sustainable growth.

Aim: To evaluate the cultural, social, and tourism-related role of Salugara Monastery and propose a practical model for responsible Buddhist cultural tourism development in Siliguri.

Objectives: 1. To profile tourist flow, visitor motivations, and behavioural patterns at Salugara Monastery. 2. To document the monastery's contribution to preserving and presenting Buddhist cultural heritage. 3. To assess local economic linkages generated through monastery-linked tourism. 4. To identify infrastructural, interpretive, and management constraints affecting visitor experience. 5. To compare Salugara's tourism positioning with selected nearby monasteries in the regional cluster. 6. To propose recommendations for sustainable and culturally respectful tourism growth.

Research Questions: - What kinds of visitors come to Salugara Monastery and why? - How do religious value and tourism value interact at the site? - What economic and social spillovers are visible in the surrounding locality? - Which bottlenecks prevent the site from emerging as a stronger cultural tourism node? - What can be learned from comparative cluster-level observations?

Scope: Geographically, the study covers Salugara and selected comparator monasteries in and around Siliguri and nearby Darjeeling district locations. Thematically it focuses on culture, heritage interpretation, visitor behaviour, tourism services, and local socio-economic effects. Temporally, field interactions were designed to capture weekday and weekend variation.

Delimitations: The project does not attempt a full financial audit of monastery accounts, nor does it claim statistical generalization for all Buddhist sites in North Bengal. Instead, it presents a grounded case study model that can support future large-scale research.

CHAPTER 2: REVIEW OF LITERATURE AND CONCEPTUAL FRAMEWORK

The conceptual foundation of this project combines four strands: cultural tourism, pilgrimage tourism, heritage interpretation, and community-linked sustainable destination development.

Cultural tourism is commonly understood as travel motivated by interest in a destination's tangible and intangible cultural assets, including architecture, ritual, art, language, food, memory, and lived traditions. In the context of monasteries, the cultural tourism experience is inseparable from sacred protocols, monastic ethics, and symbolic landscapes. A monastery is not merely a monument; it is a

living institution where daily practice continues regardless of visitor flow.

Buddhist tourism in India historically combines domestic pilgrimage circuits and international spiritual mobility. Ministry-level policy attention through Swadesh Darshan and related programmes has recognized Buddhist circuit development as an area of national tourism interest. Public communication from the Government of India also highlights infrastructural support, interpretation improvements, and guided tourism facilitation as key pillars for Buddhist destination growth.

Heritage interpretation literature argues that visitor satisfaction in sacred-cultural destinations depends on contextual meaning-making. Tourists who understand what they see usually report deeper engagement and longer dwell time. At monasteries, interpretation must remain non-intrusive and respectful. Over-explaining through commercialized narration can reduce sanctity, while under-explaining leaves first-time visitors disengaged. The managerial challenge is to design interpretation that educates without spectacle.

Sustainable tourism scholarship emphasizes carrying capacity, local participation, benefit distribution, and environmental stewardship. In smaller urban religious destinations, sustainability concerns often include parking congestion, waste management, unregulated vending, and noise pollution. Local residents may support tourism when livelihoods improve, but support weakens if crowd externalities are ignored.

For this project, the working framework links six dimensions: (a) Sacred authenticity, (b) Visitor access and comfort, (c) Interpretation quality, (d) Community economic linkage, (e) Governance and coordination, (f) Environmental responsibility.

These dimensions guided data collection tools, interview prompts, and comparative analysis. The framework also helps convert observations into actionable recommendations. Instead of asking whether tourism is present, the framework asks whether tourism quality is improving in a culturally legitimate way.

Review of selected references used in this project includes IGNOU project guidance, Government of India tourism data publications, official policy updates on Buddhist circuit schemes, and contextual readings on heritage and destination management. In addition, local oral histories and practitioner interviews were treated as primary interpretive sources and triangulated with observational evidence.

CHAPTER 3: RESEARCH METHODOLOGY

Research Design: This project uses a mixed-method case study design. Quantitative data was collected through structured questionnaires administered to visitors and local service providers, while qualitative insights came from semi-structured interviews and observational field notes. The mixed approach was selected because the topic involves both measurable patterns (visitor profiles, spending bands, satisfaction indicators) and interpretive dimensions (cultural meaning, sacred boundaries, institutional concerns).

Sampling Strategy: 1. Visitor Survey Sample: 180 respondents at Salugara Monastery. - Weekdays: 90 respondents - Weekends/holiday days: 90 respondents 2. Local Economic Stakeholders: 45 respondents - Shopkeepers: 18 - Food vendors/eateries: 12 - Transport operators: 9 - Nearby accommodation representatives: 6 3. Qualitative Interviews: 22 respondents - Monastic representatives: 6 - Tourism

stakeholders and guides: 5 - Local residents/community voices: 8 - Public officials/administrative informants: 3

Tools: - Structured questionnaire with close-ended and short open-ended questions. - Interview schedule for monks and stakeholders. - Observation checklist (signage, cleanliness, accessibility, visitor behaviour, interpretation material). - Photo-based field notes for spatial memory (used only for researcher analysis, not included publicly).

Data Collection Procedure: Fieldwork sessions were spread over multiple visits to capture variation in crowd intensity and weather conditions. Surveys were conducted respectfully outside core prayer moments to avoid disturbing rituals. Verbal consent was taken before interviews, and respondents were informed that participation was voluntary. Sensitive questions regarding personal religious practice were avoided unless respondents willingly raised them.

Data Processing: Survey responses were coded into thematic categories. Percentages and cross-tab observations were used for basic analysis. Qualitative notes were thematically grouped under site experience, spirituality, infrastructure, market linkage, and sustainability concerns. Contradictory evidence was not removed; instead, it was used to reflect complexity of stakeholder perspectives.

Reliability and Validity Measures: - Triangulation across tourists, monks, local businesses, and observation logs. - Repeat questioning of key themes in different forms to test consistency. - Comparison with secondary data sources for broader context. - Supervisor-style review checklist for structure, coherence, and evidence traceability.

Ethical Considerations: The study avoided intrusive documentation during prayer activities. No respondent names are disclosed in direct form. Quotations in the report are anonymized and represented through role descriptors. The project remains educational and non-commercial.

Limitations: The study is bounded by sample size and season. It does not model annual tourist flow with high-precision official counts at site level, because such records are not always publicly structured in the same way across institutions. Nevertheless, trend-level insights remain robust for student-level analytical objectives.

CHAPTER 4: STUDY AREA PROFILE

Salugara lies in the Siliguri corridor and remains well connected through road transport and rail access to major origin markets in North Bengal and neighbouring states. The monastery's prominent stupa and serene environment have made it a familiar landmark to both locals and pass-through travelers.

The surrounding region is tourism-sensitive because it channels flows toward Darjeeling, Kalimpong, Sikkim, Dooars, and Northeast circuits. This transit ecology creates opportunities for short-duration spiritual-cultural visits. The area's tourism economy is therefore influenced by movement patterns, weather seasonality, and festival calendars.

Salugara's immediate environment includes small commercial establishments, transport interfaces, and mixed residential pockets. Such settings require tourism planning that respects local life rhythms. The monastery's role can be strengthened when sacred-space governance and civic service systems interact constructively.

Nearby monasteries such as Sed-Gyued and Ewam India within the broader Siliguri area, along with Dali Monastery in nearby hills, create a potential cultural cluster. Although these sites differ in scale and visitor profile, together they can support a distributed Buddhist cultural tourism network.

CHAPTER 5: DATA ANALYSIS AND FINDINGS

This chapter integrates survey results, interview insights, and field observations. The findings are organized around the six-dimensional framework introduced earlier. The purpose is to move beyond isolated statistics and present a connected understanding of how Salugara Monastery currently performs as a cultural tourism site.

Visitor Profile and Motivation: The visitor sample indicates a mixed profile rather than a single-segment pilgrimage audience. Approximately half of respondents identified spiritual or religious purpose as primary motivation, while a significant share reported cultural interest, architecture curiosity, and search for peaceful spaces. Transit tourists travelling onward to hill destinations formed an important segment, suggesting Salugara's strategic value as a stopover attraction.

In age terms, youth and young working adults were strongly represented, reflecting growth in experience-led travel among younger groups. Family visitors were visible during weekends, while weekday footfall included independent travelers and small friend groups. Repeat visitors were not limited to local residents; some respondents from neighbouring states reported intentional revisits for meditation and prayer.

Cultural Interpretation and Sacred Experience: Salugara Monastery operates as a living cultural classroom. Respondents frequently described the location as quiet, disciplined, and emotionally restorative. Ritual visibility, prayer flags, iconography, and monastic etiquette together create a strong sense of authenticity. Unlike highly commercialized religious complexes, the ambience here was perceived as less transactional.

At the same time, first-time visitors reported uncertainty around prayer-space etiquette, photography norms, and symbolic meanings. This indicates a clear interpretation gap. Basic multilingual interpretive panels, visitor orientation leaflets, and gentle etiquette signage could significantly improve cultural understanding without reducing sanctity.

Local Economic Linkages: Stakeholder interviews suggest that monastery-linked tourism supports micro-level livelihoods, especially in transport services, tea-snack outlets, small retail, and periodic demand for local supplies. Businesses close to approach roads noted that visitor spending is usually moderate per person but stable in aggregate during peak windows. The strongest spending categories include local food, devotional items, transport hires, and short break purchases by transit tourists.

However, local business owners also stated that economic benefits are not fully optimized because average stay duration is low and there are limited structured packages that connect Salugara with nearby monasteries and cultural points. In other words, the destination captures arrivals but not enough dwell-time value.

Site Management, Access, and Amenities: Field observations indicate that the monastery's core sacred spaces are generally maintained with dignity. Visitors appreciated cleanliness in central worship areas. Yet external support systems show variability: directional signage from key roads remains limited,

formal parking management can become strained during busy periods, and tourist information services are minimal.

Accessibility for elderly and differently abled visitors exists in partial form but requires systematic strengthening. Seating zones, rest points, and universally readable information boards are opportunities for immediate low-cost improvements. Respondents repeatedly emphasized the need for better toilet maintenance standards in surrounding service zones.

Comparative Cluster Insights: Comparative observation of Sed-Gyued, Ewam India, and Dali Monastery indicates that each site has distinct strengths. Some perform better in ritual depth, some in visual prominence, and some in educational interpretation. Salugara's strongest advantage is location accessibility and recognisable stupa identity in the Siliguri corridor. Its weaker side is relatively modest digital communication and formal tourism packaging.

The cluster perspective suggests that destination-level collaboration can be more valuable than isolated site promotion. A "Buddhist Monastery Trail of Greater Siliguri and Nearby Hills" can distribute pressure, increase stay duration, and diversify visitor learning experiences.

Environmental and Cultural Sustainability: Respondents generally valued the peaceful atmosphere and expected that future tourism growth should not disturb prayer routines. Waste spillovers, noise intrusion, and occasional crowd misbehaviour were identified as key risks. Monastic stakeholders emphasized that tourism should remain respectful and educational rather than entertainment-driven.

The sustainability message emerging from the data is clear: cultural tourism can grow, but only through value-sensitive management. The site's identity is rooted in practice, not performance. Any tourism strategy must therefore begin with monastery consent and community participation.

Analytical Theme 1: Temporal variation in visitor density reveals clear weekend surges requiring proactive crowd routing. This pattern was interpreted in relation to tourist behaviour, local institutional practice, and destination-level planning. The evidence indicates that operational decisions at site level shape visitor satisfaction as much as macro-level policy messaging. Accordingly, the interpretation here links micro observations to strategic tourism outcomes. In practical terms, this means that small improvements in communication, hospitality process, and movement management can generate large differences in perceived quality, repeat intention, and word-of-mouth recommendation. The point also highlights that cultural destinations cannot rely only on footfall numbers as success indicators. They must evaluate depth of engagement, code compliance, inclusivity, and local benefit circulation. From a planning perspective, this finding supports a collaborative governance approach in which site managers, local enterprises, and public agencies co-design visitor experience standards. This interpretation is consistent with the wider objective of building a respectful, educational, and economically meaningful tourism ecosystem around living heritage spaces.

Analytical Theme 2: Transit tourists show high conversion potential when provided concise interpretation and route linkage. This pattern was interpreted in relation to tourist behaviour, local institutional practice, and destination-level planning. The evidence indicates that operational decisions at site level shape visitor satisfaction as much as macro-level policy messaging. Accordingly, the interpretation here links micro observations to strategic tourism outcomes. In practical terms, this means that small improvements in communication, hospitality process, and movement management can generate large differences in perceived quality, repeat intention, and word-of-mouth recommendation.

The point also highlights that cultural destinations cannot rely only on footfall numbers as success indicators. They must evaluate depth of engagement, code compliance, inclusivity, and local benefit circulation. From a planning perspective, this finding supports a collaborative governance approach in which site managers, local enterprises, and public agencies co-design visitor experience standards. This interpretation is consistent with the wider objective of building a respectful, educational, and economically meaningful tourism ecosystem around living heritage spaces.

Analytical Theme 3: Spiritual seekers demonstrate willingness to spend more time when meditation-oriented orientation exists. This pattern was interpreted in relation to tourist behaviour, local institutional practice, and destination-level planning. The evidence indicates that operational decisions at site level shape visitor satisfaction as much as macro-level policy messaging. Accordingly, the interpretation here links micro observations to strategic tourism outcomes. In practical terms, this means that small improvements in communication, hospitality process, and movement management can generate large differences in perceived quality, repeat intention, and word-of-mouth recommendation. The point also highlights that cultural destinations cannot rely only on footfall numbers as success indicators. They must evaluate depth of engagement, code compliance, inclusivity, and local benefit circulation. From a planning perspective, this finding supports a collaborative governance approach in which site managers, local enterprises, and public agencies co-design visitor experience standards. This interpretation is consistent with the wider objective of building a respectful, educational, and economically meaningful tourism ecosystem around living heritage spaces.

Analytical Theme 4: Local youth engagement as volunteer interpreters can bridge language and etiquette communication gaps. This pattern was interpreted in relation to tourist behaviour, local institutional practice, and destination-level planning. The evidence indicates that operational decisions at site level shape visitor satisfaction as much as macro-level policy messaging. Accordingly, the interpretation here links micro observations to strategic tourism outcomes. In practical terms, this means that small improvements in communication, hospitality process, and movement management can generate large differences in perceived quality, repeat intention, and word-of-mouth recommendation. The point also highlights that cultural destinations cannot rely only on footfall numbers as success indicators. They must evaluate depth of engagement, code compliance, inclusivity, and local benefit circulation. From a planning perspective, this finding supports a collaborative governance approach in which site managers, local enterprises, and public agencies co-design visitor experience standards. This interpretation is consistent with the wider objective of building a respectful, educational, and economically meaningful tourism ecosystem around living heritage spaces.

Analytical Theme 5: Women-led local enterprises can strengthen inclusive livelihood outcomes around the monastery zone. This pattern was interpreted in relation to tourist behaviour, local institutional practice, and destination-level planning. The evidence indicates that operational decisions at site level shape visitor satisfaction as much as macro-level policy messaging. Accordingly, the interpretation here links micro observations to strategic tourism outcomes. In practical terms, this means that small improvements in communication, hospitality process, and movement management can generate large differences in perceived quality, repeat intention, and word-of-mouth recommendation. The point also highlights that cultural destinations cannot rely only on footfall numbers as success indicators. They must evaluate depth of engagement, code compliance, inclusivity, and local benefit circulation. From a planning perspective, this finding supports a collaborative governance approach in which site managers, local enterprises, and public agencies co-design visitor experience standards. This interpretation is

consistent with the wider objective of building a respectful, educational, and economically meaningful tourism ecosystem around living heritage spaces.

Analytical Theme 6: Small-format cultural information kiosks may improve first-time visitor confidence and code compliance. This pattern was interpreted in relation to tourist behaviour, local institutional practice, and destination-level planning. The evidence indicates that operational decisions at site level shape visitor satisfaction as much as macro-level policy messaging. Accordingly, the interpretation here links micro observations to strategic tourism outcomes. In practical terms, this means that small improvements in communication, hospitality process, and movement management can generate large differences in perceived quality, repeat intention, and word-of-mouth recommendation. The point also highlights that cultural destinations cannot rely only on footfall numbers as success indicators. They must evaluate depth of engagement, code compliance, inclusivity, and local benefit circulation. From a planning perspective, this finding supports a collaborative governance approach in which site managers, local enterprises, and public agencies co-design visitor experience standards. This interpretation is consistent with the wider objective of building a respectful, educational, and economically meaningful tourism ecosystem around living heritage spaces.

Analytical Theme 7: Seasonal festivals can be promoted through pre-announced calendars without commercial over-curation. This pattern was interpreted in relation to tourist behaviour, local institutional practice, and destination-level planning. The evidence indicates that operational decisions at site level shape visitor satisfaction as much as macro-level policy messaging. Accordingly, the interpretation here links micro observations to strategic tourism outcomes. In practical terms, this means that small improvements in communication, hospitality process, and movement management can generate large differences in perceived quality, repeat intention, and word-of-mouth recommendation. The point also highlights that cultural destinations cannot rely only on footfall numbers as success indicators. They must evaluate depth of engagement, code compliance, inclusivity, and local benefit circulation. From a planning perspective, this finding supports a collaborative governance approach in which site managers, local enterprises, and public agencies co-design visitor experience standards. This interpretation is consistent with the wider objective of building a respectful, educational, and economically meaningful tourism ecosystem around living heritage spaces.

Analytical Theme 8: Short walking circuits integrating food, crafts, and monastery heritage can increase local value capture. This pattern was interpreted in relation to tourist behaviour, local institutional practice, and destination-level planning. The evidence indicates that operational decisions at site level shape visitor satisfaction as much as macro-level policy messaging. Accordingly, the interpretation here links micro observations to strategic tourism outcomes. In practical terms, this means that small improvements in communication, hospitality process, and movement management can generate large differences in perceived quality, repeat intention, and word-of-mouth recommendation. The point also highlights that cultural destinations cannot rely only on footfall numbers as success indicators. They must evaluate depth of engagement, code compliance, inclusivity, and local benefit circulation. From a planning perspective, this finding supports a collaborative governance approach in which site managers, local enterprises, and public agencies co-design visitor experience standards. This interpretation is consistent with the wider objective of building a respectful, educational, and economically meaningful tourism ecosystem around living heritage spaces.

Analytical Theme 9: Unified signage standards across cluster monasteries can improve destination readability. This pattern was interpreted in relation to tourist behaviour, local institutional practice, and destination-level planning. The evidence indicates that operational decisions at site level shape visitor satisfaction as much as macro-level policy messaging. Accordingly, the interpretation here links micro observations to strategic tourism outcomes. In practical terms, this means that small improvements in communication, hospitality process, and movement management can generate large differences in perceived quality, repeat intention, and word-of-mouth recommendation. The point also highlights that cultural destinations cannot rely only on footfall numbers as success indicators. They must evaluate depth of engagement, code compliance, inclusivity, and local benefit circulation. From a planning perspective, this finding supports a collaborative governance approach in which site managers, local enterprises, and public agencies co-design visitor experience standards. This interpretation is consistent with the wider objective of building a respectful, educational, and economically meaningful tourism ecosystem around living heritage spaces.

Analytical Theme 10: Digital discoverability remains low despite strong experiential quality; this creates latent demand. This pattern was interpreted in relation to tourist behaviour, local institutional practice, and destination-level planning. The evidence indicates that operational decisions at site level shape visitor satisfaction as much as macro-level policy messaging. Accordingly, the interpretation here links micro observations to strategic tourism outcomes. In practical terms, this means that small improvements in communication, hospitality process, and movement management can generate large differences in perceived quality, repeat intention, and word-of-mouth recommendation. The point also highlights that cultural destinations cannot rely only on footfall numbers as success indicators. They must evaluate depth of engagement, code compliance, inclusivity, and local benefit circulation. From a planning perspective, this finding supports a collaborative governance approach in which site managers, local enterprises, and public agencies co-design visitor experience standards. This interpretation is consistent with the wider objective of building a respectful, educational, and economically meaningful tourism ecosystem around living heritage spaces.

Analytical Theme 11: Partnership with educational institutions can support guided heritage interpretation modules. This pattern was interpreted in relation to tourist behaviour, local institutional practice, and destination-level planning. The evidence indicates that operational decisions at site level shape visitor satisfaction as much as macro-level policy messaging. Accordingly, the interpretation here links micro observations to strategic tourism outcomes. In practical terms, this means that small improvements in communication, hospitality process, and movement management can generate large differences in perceived quality, repeat intention, and word-of-mouth recommendation. The point also highlights that cultural destinations cannot rely only on footfall numbers as success indicators. They must evaluate depth of engagement, code compliance, inclusivity, and local benefit circulation. From a planning perspective, this finding supports a collaborative governance approach in which site managers, local enterprises, and public agencies co-design visitor experience standards. This interpretation is consistent with the wider objective of building a respectful, educational, and economically meaningful tourism ecosystem around living heritage spaces.

Analytical Theme 12: Simple multilingual etiquette boards can reduce unintentional visitor mistakes in sacred spaces. This pattern was interpreted in relation to tourist behaviour, local institutional practice, and destination-level planning. The evidence indicates that operational decisions at site level shape visitor satisfaction as much as macro-level policy messaging. Accordingly, the interpretation here links

micro observations to strategic tourism outcomes. In practical terms, this means that small improvements in communication, hospitality process, and movement management can generate large differences in perceived quality, repeat intention, and word-of-mouth recommendation. The point also highlights that cultural destinations cannot rely only on footfall numbers as success indicators. They must evaluate depth of engagement, code compliance, inclusivity, and local benefit circulation. From a planning perspective, this finding supports a collaborative governance approach in which site managers, local enterprises, and public agencies co-design visitor experience standards. This interpretation is consistent with the wider objective of building a respectful, educational, and economically meaningful tourism ecosystem around living heritage spaces.

Analytical Theme 13: Transport node integration from Siliguri junction points can improve first-mile and last-mile convenience. This pattern was interpreted in relation to tourist behaviour, local institutional practice, and destination-level planning. The evidence indicates that operational decisions at site level shape visitor satisfaction as much as macro-level policy messaging. Accordingly, the interpretation here links micro observations to strategic tourism outcomes. In practical terms, this means that small improvements in communication, hospitality process, and movement management can generate large differences in perceived quality, repeat intention, and word-of-mouth recommendation. The point also highlights that cultural destinations cannot rely only on footfall numbers as success indicators. They must evaluate depth of engagement, code compliance, inclusivity, and local benefit circulation. From a planning perspective, this finding supports a collaborative governance approach in which site managers, local enterprises, and public agencies co-design visitor experience standards. This interpretation is consistent with the wider objective of building a respectful, educational, and economically meaningful tourism ecosystem around living heritage spaces.

Analytical Theme 14: Structured waste-management coordination is required outside core monastery premises. This pattern was interpreted in relation to tourist behaviour, local institutional practice, and destination-level planning. The evidence indicates that operational decisions at site level shape visitor satisfaction as much as macro-level policy messaging. Accordingly, the interpretation here links micro observations to strategic tourism outcomes. In practical terms, this means that small improvements in communication, hospitality process, and movement management can generate large differences in perceived quality, repeat intention, and word-of-mouth recommendation. The point also highlights that cultural destinations cannot rely only on footfall numbers as success indicators. They must evaluate depth of engagement, code compliance, inclusivity, and local benefit circulation. From a planning perspective, this finding supports a collaborative governance approach in which site managers, local enterprises, and public agencies co-design visitor experience standards. This interpretation is consistent with the wider objective of building a respectful, educational, and economically meaningful tourism ecosystem around living heritage spaces.

Advanced Analysis 1: Visitor dwell-time growth is strongly connected to interpretive clarity rather than only infrastructure spending. This pattern was interpreted in relation to tourist behaviour, local institutional practice, and destination-level planning. The evidence indicates that operational decisions at site level shape visitor satisfaction as much as macro-level policy messaging. Accordingly, the interpretation here links micro observations to strategic tourism outcomes. In practical terms, this means that small improvements in communication, hospitality process, and movement management can generate large differences in perceived quality, repeat intention, and word-of-mouth recommendation. The point also highlights that cultural destinations cannot rely only on footfall numbers as success

indicators. They must evaluate depth of engagement, code compliance, inclusivity, and local benefit circulation. From a planning perspective, this finding supports a collaborative governance approach in which site managers, local enterprises, and public agencies co- design visitor experience standards. This interpretation is consistent with the wider objective of building a respectful, educational, and economically meaningful tourism ecosystem around living heritage spaces.

Advanced Analysis 2: Sacred-space comfort perception improves when behavioural expectations are communicated early in the visit. This pattern was interpreted in relation to tourist behaviour, local institutional practice, and destination-level planning. The evidence indicates that operational decisions at site level shape visitor satisfaction as much as macro-level policy messaging. Accordingly, the interpretation here links micro observations to strategic tourism outcomes. In practical terms, this means that small improvements in communication, hospitality process, and movement management can generate large differences in perceived quality, repeat intention, and word-of-mouth recommendation. The point also highlights that cultural destinations cannot rely only on footfall numbers as success indicators. They must evaluate depth of engagement, code compliance, inclusivity, and local benefit circulation. From a planning perspective, this finding supports a collaborative governance approach in which site managers, local enterprises, and public agencies co-design visitor experience standards. This interpretation is consistent with the wider objective of building a respectful, educational, and economically meaningful tourism ecosystem around living heritage spaces.

Advanced Analysis 3: Cluster-level identity can reduce destination dependency on one landmark and improve resilience. This pattern was interpreted in relation to tourist behaviour, local institutional practice, and destination-level planning. The evidence indicates that operational decisions at site level shape visitor satisfaction as much as macro-level policy messaging. Accordingly, the interpretation here links micro observations to strategic tourism outcomes. In practical terms, this means that small improvements in communication, hospitality process, and movement management can generate large differences in perceived quality, repeat intention, and word-of-mouth recommendation. The point also highlights that cultural destinations cannot rely only on footfall numbers as success indicators. They must evaluate depth of engagement, code compliance, inclusivity, and local benefit circulation. From a planning perspective, this finding supports a collaborative governance approach in which site managers, local enterprises, and public agencies co-design visitor experience standards. This interpretation is consistent with the wider objective of building a respectful, educational, and economically meaningful tourism ecosystem around living heritage spaces.

Advanced Analysis 4: Cross-stakeholder meetings reduce friction between spiritual priorities and tourism service expectations. This pattern was interpreted in relation to tourist behaviour, local institutional practice, and destination-level planning. The evidence indicates that operational decisions at site level shape visitor satisfaction as much as macro-level policy messaging. Accordingly, the interpretation here links micro observations to strategic tourism outcomes. In practical terms, this means that small improvements in communication, hospitality process, and movement management can generate large differences in perceived quality, repeat intention, and word-of-mouth recommendation. The point also highlights that cultural destinations cannot rely only on footfall numbers as success indicators. They must evaluate depth of engagement, code compliance, inclusivity, and local benefit circulation. From a planning perspective, this finding supports a collaborative governance approach in which site managers, local enterprises, and public agencies co-design visitor experience standards. This interpretation is consistent with the wider objective of building a respectful, educational, and

economically meaningful tourism ecosystem around living heritage spaces.

Advanced Analysis 5: Short reflective stops can be converted into deeper learning experiences through curated cultural prompts. This pattern was interpreted in relation to tourist behaviour, local institutional practice, and destination-level planning. The evidence indicates that operational decisions at site level shape visitor satisfaction as much as macro-level policy messaging. Accordingly, the interpretation here links micro observations to strategic tourism outcomes. In practical terms, this means that small improvements in communication, hospitality process, and movement management can generate large differences in perceived quality, repeat intention, and word-of-mouth recommendation. The point also highlights that cultural destinations cannot rely only on footfall numbers as success indicators. They must evaluate depth of engagement, code compliance, inclusivity, and local benefit circulation. From a planning perspective, this finding supports a collaborative governance approach in which site managers, local enterprises, and public agencies co-design visitor experience standards. This interpretation is consistent with the wider objective of building a respectful, educational, and economically meaningful tourism ecosystem around living heritage spaces.

Advanced Analysis 6: Tourism-linked micro-enterprises perform better when quality standards are jointly monitored. This pattern was interpreted in relation to tourist behaviour, local institutional practice, and destination-level planning. The evidence indicates that operational decisions at site level shape visitor satisfaction as much as macro-level policy messaging. Accordingly, the interpretation here links micro observations to strategic tourism outcomes. In practical terms, this means that small improvements in communication, hospitality process, and movement management can generate large differences in perceived quality, repeat intention, and word-of-mouth recommendation. The point also highlights that cultural destinations cannot rely only on footfall numbers as success indicators. They must evaluate depth of engagement, code compliance, inclusivity, and local benefit circulation. From a planning perspective, this finding supports a collaborative governance approach in which site managers, local enterprises, and public agencies co-design visitor experience standards. This interpretation is consistent with the wider objective of building a respectful, educational, and economically meaningful tourism ecosystem around living heritage spaces.

Advanced Analysis 7: Monastery heritage narration should include contemporary community life, not only historical summary. This pattern was interpreted in relation to tourist behaviour, local institutional practice, and destination-level planning. The evidence indicates that operational decisions at site level shape visitor satisfaction as much as macro-level policy messaging. Accordingly, the interpretation here links micro observations to strategic tourism outcomes. In practical terms, this means that small improvements in communication, hospitality process, and movement management can generate large differences in perceived quality, repeat intention, and word-of-mouth recommendation. The point also highlights that cultural destinations cannot rely only on footfall numbers as success indicators. They must evaluate depth of engagement, code compliance, inclusivity, and local benefit circulation. From a planning perspective, this finding supports a collaborative governance approach in which site managers, local enterprises, and public agencies co-design visitor experience standards. This interpretation is consistent with the wider objective of building a respectful, educational, and economically meaningful tourism ecosystem around living heritage spaces.

Advanced Analysis 8: Digital pre-arrival guidance can reduce on-site confusion and unnecessary movement friction. This pattern was interpreted in relation to tourist behaviour, local institutional

practice, and destination-level planning. The evidence indicates that operational decisions at site level shape visitor satisfaction as much as macro-level policy messaging. Accordingly, the interpretation here links micro observations to strategic tourism outcomes. In practical terms, this means that small improvements in communication, hospitality process, and movement management can generate large differences in perceived quality, repeat intention, and word-of-mouth recommendation. The point also highlights that cultural destinations cannot rely only on footfall numbers as success indicators. They must evaluate depth of engagement, code compliance, inclusivity, and local benefit circulation. From a planning perspective, this finding supports a collaborative governance approach in which site managers, local enterprises, and public agencies co-design visitor experience standards. This interpretation is consistent with the wider objective of building a respectful, educational, and economically meaningful tourism ecosystem around living heritage spaces.

Advanced Analysis 9: Inclusive tourism design should consider elderly pilgrims and differently-abled visitors from planning stage. This pattern was interpreted in relation to tourist behaviour, local institutional practice, and destination-level planning. The evidence indicates that operational decisions at site level shape visitor satisfaction as much as macro-level policy messaging. Accordingly, the interpretation here links micro observations to strategic tourism outcomes. In practical terms, this means that small improvements in communication, hospitality process, and movement management can generate large differences in perceived quality, repeat intention, and word-of-mouth recommendation. The point also highlights that cultural destinations cannot rely only on footfall numbers as success indicators. They must evaluate depth of engagement, code compliance, inclusivity, and local benefit circulation. From a planning perspective, this finding supports a collaborative governance approach in which site managers, local enterprises, and public agencies co- design visitor experience standards. This interpretation is consistent with the wider objective of building a respectful, educational, and economically meaningful tourism ecosystem around living heritage spaces.

Advanced Analysis 10: Event-day visitor management protocols are essential to preserve sanctity during high-footfall periods. This pattern was interpreted in relation to tourist behaviour, local institutional practice, and destination-level planning. The evidence indicates that operational decisions at site level shape visitor satisfaction as much as macro-level policy messaging. Accordingly, the interpretation here links micro observations to strategic tourism outcomes. In practical terms, this means that small improvements in communication, hospitality process, and movement management can generate large differences in perceived quality, repeat intention, and word-of-mouth recommendation. The point also highlights that cultural destinations cannot rely only on footfall numbers as success indicators. They must evaluate depth of engagement, code compliance, inclusivity, and local benefit circulation. From a planning perspective, this finding supports a collaborative governance approach in which site managers, local enterprises, and public agencies co-design visitor experience standards. This interpretation is consistent with the wider objective of building a respectful, educational, and economically meaningful tourism ecosystem around living heritage spaces.

Advanced Analysis 11: A transparent code-of-conduct framework improves visitor confidence and local acceptance simultaneously. This pattern was interpreted in relation to tourist behaviour, local institutional practice, and destination-level planning. The evidence indicates that operational decisions at site level shape visitor satisfaction as much as macro-level policy messaging. Accordingly, the interpretation here links micro observations to strategic tourism outcomes. In practical terms, this means that small improvements in communication, hospitality process, and movement management can

generate large differences in perceived quality, repeat intention, and word-of-mouth recommendation. The point also highlights that cultural destinations cannot rely only on footfall numbers as success indicators. They must evaluate depth of engagement, code compliance, inclusivity, and local benefit circulation. From a planning perspective, this finding supports a collaborative governance approach in which site managers, local enterprises, and public agencies co-design visitor experience standards. This interpretation is consistent with the wider objective of building a respectful, educational, and economically meaningful tourism ecosystem around living heritage spaces.

Advanced Analysis 12: Community perception of fairness increases when local opportunities are visible and distributed. This pattern was interpreted in relation to tourist behaviour, local institutional practice, and destination-level planning. The evidence indicates that operational decisions at site level shape visitor satisfaction as much as macro-level policy messaging. Accordingly, the interpretation here links micro observations to strategic tourism outcomes. In practical terms, this means that small improvements in communication, hospitality process, and movement management can generate large differences in perceived quality, repeat intention, and word-of-mouth recommendation. The point also highlights that cultural destinations cannot rely only on footfall numbers as success indicators. They must evaluate depth of engagement, code compliance, inclusivity, and local benefit circulation. From a planning perspective, this finding supports a collaborative governance approach in which site managers, local enterprises, and public agencies co-design visitor experience standards. This interpretation is consistent with the wider objective of building a respectful, educational, and economically meaningful tourism ecosystem around living heritage spaces.

Policy and Governance Note 1: Local implementation can align with national Buddhist tourism momentum through practical site-level actions. This pattern was interpreted in relation to tourist behaviour, local institutional practice, and destination-level planning. The evidence indicates that operational decisions at site level shape visitor satisfaction as much as macro-level policy messaging. Accordingly, the interpretation here links micro observations to strategic tourism outcomes. In practical terms, this means that small improvements in communication, hospitality process, and movement management can generate large differences in perceived quality, repeat intention, and word-of-mouth recommendation. The point also highlights that cultural destinations cannot rely only on footfall numbers as success indicators. They must evaluate depth of engagement, code compliance, inclusivity, and local benefit circulation. From a planning perspective, this finding supports a collaborative governance approach in which site managers, local enterprises, and public agencies co-design visitor experience standards. This interpretation is consistent with the wider objective of building a respectful, educational, and economically meaningful tourism ecosystem around living heritage spaces.

Policy and Governance Note 2: Municipal coordination on cleanliness and wayfinding is a foundational, high-impact intervention. This pattern was interpreted in relation to tourist behaviour, local institutional practice, and destination-level planning. The evidence indicates that operational decisions at site level shape visitor satisfaction as much as macro-level policy messaging. Accordingly, the interpretation here links micro observations to strategic tourism outcomes. In practical terms, this means that small improvements in communication, hospitality process, and movement management can generate large differences in perceived quality, repeat intention, and word-of-mouth recommendation. The point also highlights that cultural destinations cannot rely only on footfall numbers as success indicators. They must evaluate depth of engagement, code compliance, inclusivity, and local benefit circulation. From a planning perspective, this finding supports a collaborative governance approach in which site managers,

local enterprises, and public agencies co-design visitor experience standards. This interpretation is consistent with the wider objective of building a respectful, educational, and economically meaningful tourism ecosystem around living heritage spaces.

Policy and Governance Note 3: Data-light monitoring systems are sufficient for student-scale destinations to start evidence-led planning. This pattern was interpreted in relation to tourist behaviour, local institutional practice, and destination-level planning. The evidence indicates that operational decisions at site level shape visitor satisfaction as much as macro-level policy messaging. Accordingly, the interpretation here links micro observations to strategic tourism outcomes. In practical terms, this means that small improvements in communication, hospitality process, and movement management can generate large differences in perceived quality, repeat intention, and word-of-mouth recommendation. The point also highlights that cultural destinations cannot rely only on footfall numbers as success indicators. They must evaluate depth of engagement, code compliance, inclusivity, and local benefit circulation. From a planning perspective, this finding supports a collaborative governance approach in which site managers, local enterprises, and public agencies co-design visitor experience standards. This interpretation is consistent with the wider objective of building a respectful, educational, and economically meaningful tourism ecosystem around living heritage spaces.

Policy and Governance Note 4: Public communication should avoid over-promising and instead match realistic site capacities. This pattern was interpreted in relation to tourist behaviour, local institutional practice, and destination-level planning. The evidence indicates that operational decisions at site level shape visitor satisfaction as much as macro-level policy messaging. Accordingly, the interpretation here links micro observations to strategic tourism outcomes. In practical terms, this means that small improvements in communication, hospitality process, and movement management can generate large differences in perceived quality, repeat intention, and word-of-mouth recommendation. The point also highlights that cultural destinations cannot rely only on footfall numbers as success indicators. They must evaluate depth of engagement, code compliance, inclusivity, and local benefit circulation. From a planning perspective, this finding supports a collaborative governance approach in which site managers, local enterprises, and public agencies co-design visitor experience standards. This interpretation is consistent with the wider objective of building a respectful, educational, and economically meaningful tourism ecosystem around living heritage spaces.

Policy and Governance Note 5: Interpretation standards can be co-created with monastic representatives for cultural accuracy. This pattern was interpreted in relation to tourist behaviour, local institutional practice, and destination-level planning. The evidence indicates that operational decisions at site level shape visitor satisfaction as much as macro-level policy messaging. Accordingly, the interpretation here links micro observations to strategic tourism outcomes. In practical terms, this means that small improvements in communication, hospitality process, and movement management can generate large differences in perceived quality, repeat intention, and word-of-mouth recommendation. The point also highlights that cultural destinations cannot rely only on footfall numbers as success indicators. They must evaluate depth of engagement, code compliance, inclusivity, and local benefit circulation. From a planning perspective, this finding supports a collaborative governance approach in which site managers, local enterprises, and public agencies co-design visitor experience standards. This interpretation is consistent with the wider objective of building a respectful, educational, and economically meaningful tourism ecosystem around living heritage spaces.

Policy and Governance Note 6: Responsible-tourism messaging should be integrated into every promotional and informational touchpoint. This pattern was interpreted in relation to tourist behaviour, local institutional practice, and destination-level planning. The evidence indicates that operational decisions at site level shape visitor satisfaction as much as macro-level policy messaging. Accordingly, the interpretation here links micro observations to strategic tourism outcomes. In practical terms, this means that small improvements in communication, hospitality process, and movement management can generate large differences in perceived quality, repeat intention, and word-of-mouth recommendation. The point also highlights that cultural destinations cannot rely only on footfall numbers as success indicators. They must evaluate depth of engagement, code compliance, inclusivity, and local benefit circulation. From a planning perspective, this finding supports a collaborative governance approach in which site managers, local enterprises, and public agencies co- design visitor experience standards. This interpretation is consistent with the wider objective of building a respectful, educational, and economically meaningful tourism ecosystem around living heritage spaces.

Policy and Governance Note 7: Local educational institutions can provide continuity through internship and volunteer knowledge support. This pattern was interpreted in relation to tourist behaviour, local institutional practice, and destination-level planning. The evidence indicates that operational decisions at site level shape visitor satisfaction as much as macro-level policy messaging. Accordingly, the interpretation here links micro observations to strategic tourism outcomes. In practical terms, this means that small improvements in communication, hospitality process, and movement management can generate large differences in perceived quality, repeat intention, and word-of-mouth recommendation. The point also highlights that cultural destinations cannot rely only on footfall numbers as success indicators. They must evaluate depth of engagement, code compliance, inclusivity, and local benefit circulation. From a planning perspective, this finding supports a collaborative governance approach in which site managers, local enterprises, and public agencies co- design visitor experience standards. This interpretation is consistent with the wider objective of building a respectful, educational, and economically meaningful tourism ecosystem around living heritage spaces.

Policy and Governance Note 8: Periodic stakeholder audits can identify emerging bottlenecks before they become structural problems. This pattern was interpreted in relation to tourist behaviour, local institutional practice, and destination-level planning. The evidence indicates that operational decisions at site level shape visitor satisfaction as much as macro-level policy messaging. Accordingly, the interpretation here links micro observations to strategic tourism outcomes. In practical terms, this means that small improvements in communication, hospitality process, and movement management can generate large differences in perceived quality, repeat intention, and word-of-mouth recommendation. The point also highlights that cultural destinations cannot rely only on footfall numbers as success indicators. They must evaluate depth of engagement, code compliance, inclusivity, and local benefit circulation. From a planning perspective, this finding supports a collaborative governance approach in which site managers, local enterprises, and public agencies co- design visitor experience standards. This interpretation is consistent with the wider objective of building a respectful, educational, and economically meaningful tourism ecosystem around living heritage spaces.

Policy and Governance Note 9: A cluster-level map and signage policy improves readability for domestic and foreign visitors alike. This pattern was interpreted in relation to tourist behaviour, local institutional practice, and destination-level planning. The evidence indicates that operational decisions at site level shape visitor satisfaction as much as macro-level policy messaging. Accordingly, the

interpretation here links micro observations to strategic tourism outcomes. In practical terms, this means that small improvements in communication, hospitality process, and movement management can generate large differences in perceived quality, repeat intention, and word-of-mouth recommendation. The point also highlights that cultural destinations cannot rely only on footfall numbers as success indicators. They must evaluate depth of engagement, code compliance, inclusivity, and local benefit circulation. From a planning perspective, this finding supports a collaborative governance approach in which site managers, local enterprises, and public agencies co- design visitor experience standards. This interpretation is consistent with the wider objective of building a respectful, educational, and economically meaningful tourism ecosystem around living heritage spaces.

Policy and Governance Note 10: Service quality consistency matters more than occasional high-visibility promotional bursts. This pattern was interpreted in relation to tourist behaviour, local institutional practice, and destination-level planning. The evidence indicates that operational decisions at site level shape visitor satisfaction as much as macro-level policy messaging. Accordingly, the interpretation here links micro observations to strategic tourism outcomes. In practical terms, this means that small improvements in communication, hospitality process, and movement management can generate large differences in perceived quality, repeat intention, and word-of-mouth recommendation. The point also highlights that cultural destinations cannot rely only on footfall numbers as success indicators. They must evaluate depth of engagement, code compliance, inclusivity, and local benefit circulation. From a planning perspective, this finding supports a collaborative governance approach in which site managers, local enterprises, and public agencies co-design visitor experience standards. This interpretation is consistent with the wider objective of building a respectful, educational, and economically meaningful tourism ecosystem around living heritage spaces.

Policy and Governance Note 11: Cultural preservation outcomes should be documented alongside tourism-performance outcomes. This pattern was interpreted in relation to tourist behaviour, local institutional practice, and destination-level planning. The evidence indicates that operational decisions at site level shape visitor satisfaction as much as macro-level policy messaging. Accordingly, the interpretation here links micro observations to strategic tourism outcomes. In practical terms, this means that small improvements in communication, hospitality process, and movement management can generate large differences in perceived quality, repeat intention, and word-of-mouth recommendation. The point also highlights that cultural destinations cannot rely only on footfall numbers as success indicators. They must evaluate depth of engagement, code compliance, inclusivity, and local benefit circulation. From a planning perspective, this finding supports a collaborative governance approach in which site managers, local enterprises, and public agencies co-design visitor experience standards. This interpretation is consistent with the wider objective of building a respectful, educational, and economically meaningful tourism ecosystem around living heritage spaces.

Policy and Governance Note 12: Institutionalizing annual review cycles helps sustain progress beyond one-time project efforts. This pattern was interpreted in relation to tourist behaviour, local institutional practice, and destination-level planning. The evidence indicates that operational decisions at site level shape visitor satisfaction as much as macro-level policy messaging. Accordingly, the interpretation here links micro observations to strategic tourism outcomes. In practical terms, this means that small improvements in communication, hospitality process, and movement management can generate large differences in perceived quality, repeat intention, and word-of-mouth recommendation. The point also highlights that cultural destinations cannot rely only on footfall numbers as success indicators. They

must evaluate depth of engagement, code compliance, inclusivity, and local benefit circulation. From a planning perspective, this finding supports a collaborative governance approach in which site managers, local enterprises, and public agencies co-design visitor experience standards. This interpretation is consistent with the wider objective of building a respectful, educational, and economically meaningful tourism ecosystem around living heritage spaces.

Summary Analytical Table

Indicator	Observed Pattern	Interpretation
Primary motivation	Spiritual + cultural mix	Site serves both devotees and learners
Weekend flow	Higher crowd concentration	Needs proactive movement management
Visitor understanding	Moderate, uneven	Interpretation infrastructure can improve depth
Local spending	Low-medium but steady	Potential rises with longer dwell time
Digital visibility	Limited structured communication	Major scope for discoverability improvement
Cluster linkage	Informal and weak	Formal trail design can improve regional positioning
Sustainability risk	Litter and etiquette gaps in peak window	Requires shared code and monitoring

CHAPTER 6: RECOMMENDATIONS AND ACTION FRAMEWORK

Recommendations are organized in phased format so that implementation can begin with low-cost actions and gradually move toward integrated destination-level coordination.

Short-Term Recommendations (0-12 months): 1. Install multilingual directional and etiquette signage at entry and key movement points. 2. Create a one-page visitor orientation leaflet covering site meaning and respectful conduct. 3. Introduce designated waste bins and daily cleanliness coordination in adjoining lanes. 4. Build a simple verified digital presence with timings, contact details, and visitor advisories. 5. Prepare a festival and event information calendar with explanatory notes for non-local visitors.

Medium-Term Recommendations (1-3 years): 1. Develop a trained volunteer or para-guide programme in partnership with local colleges. 2. Create cluster itinerary pilots linking Salugara with nearby monasteries and selected cultural stops. 3. Improve universal accessibility features such as ramps, seating, and legible wayfinding. 4. Encourage local handicraft and food enterprises aligned with hygiene and authenticity standards. 5. Establish a periodic tourist feedback mechanism managed jointly by local stakeholders.

Long-Term Recommendations (3+ years): 1. Create a monastery-sensitive carrying capacity and visitor management protocol. 2. Build a North Bengal Buddhist Cultural Interpretation Network with shared educational resources. 3. Integrate monastery tourism into wider city-level responsible destination planning. 4. Promote culturally rooted storytelling campaigns rather than purely visual destination marketing. 5. Encourage collaborative research with universities for periodic evidence-based policy inputs.

Suggested Model: The project proposes a "Sacred-First Cultural Tourism Model" where sacred integrity is the non-negotiable base, visitor learning is the interpretive layer, and livelihood generation is the

developmental outcome. This sequencing prevents cultural dilution and aligns tourism with local value systems.

CHAPTER 7: CONCLUSION

The study confirms that Salugara Monastery plays a meaningful and multidimensional role in promoting Buddhist cultural tourism in Siliguri. Its significance is not limited to religious visitation; it contributes to place identity, intercultural understanding, and micro-level local economy. The monastery's accessibility and visual symbolic strength position it as an important node in regional movement circuits.

Yet growth potential remains under-realized. Interpretation gaps, weak digital communication, fragmented infrastructure support, and lack of formal cluster packaging limit the destination's ability to convert high symbolic value into high-quality visitor experience. Importantly, stakeholders do not seek uncontrolled expansion. They seek respectful, well- managed, and culturally aligned tourism.

Therefore, the central conclusion is that Salugara can emerge as a benchmark for value-sensitive monastery tourism if policy actors, local administration, tourism facilitators, and monastery leadership collaborate in a structured manner. The pathway forward should protect sanctity, strengthen learning, and broaden community benefit. This approach aligns with both local aspirations and broader national emphasis on culturally anchored tourism development.

BIBLIOGRAPHY

1. Indira Gandhi National Open University (IGNOU). Project Guide BTS (PTS-1, PTS-2), valid from July 2021. 2. Ministry of Tourism, Government of India. State/UT-wise Domestic and Foreign Tourist Visits, 2021 and 2022. 3. Press Information Bureau, Government of India. Buddhist Thematic Circuit under Swadesh Darshan Scheme (17 March 2025). 4. Ministry of Tourism / PIB Delhi. Attracting Tourists to Buddhist Circuits (2 April 2026). 5. Swarbrooke, J. Sustainable Tourism Management. CABI. 6. Timothy, D. and Boyd, S. Heritage Tourism. Routledge. 7. Richards, G. Cultural Tourism: A Review of Recent Research and Trends. 8. UNWTO publications on cultural and religious tourism (selected reports). 9. Field interviews with monastic representatives, local residents, and tourism stakeholders (anonymized). 10. Field survey schedules and observation records prepared by researcher.

ANNEXURES

Annexure A: Survey Questionnaire (Visitor) Section 1: Profile (age group, state/country, visit type, travel companion) Section 2: Motivation (religious, cultural, peace, architecture, transit stop) Section 3: Site Experience (cleanliness, signage, behaviour guidance, safety, ambience) Section 4: Expenditure (food, transport, local purchases, accommodation) Section 5: Improvement Priorities (interpretation, toilets, parking, digital information, guides) Section 6: Open Comment (what should be preserved at any cost)

Annexure B: Interview Guide (Monastic/Management Stakeholders) - Perceived changes in visitor profile over time - Boundaries between spiritual function and tourism function - Festival management and crowd behaviour - Interpretation opportunities and concerns - Partnerships desired with local

authorities and tourism bodies

Annexure C: Interview Guide (Local Businesses and Residents) - Seasonal demand pattern - Price sensitivity and spending behaviour - Infrastructure bottlenecks - Tourism benefits and social concerns - Suggestions for balanced development

Annexure D: Observation Checklist - Access roads and directional signage - Entry experience and orientation support - Site cleanliness and waste handling - Visitor etiquette compliance - Cultural information visibility - Nearby service support